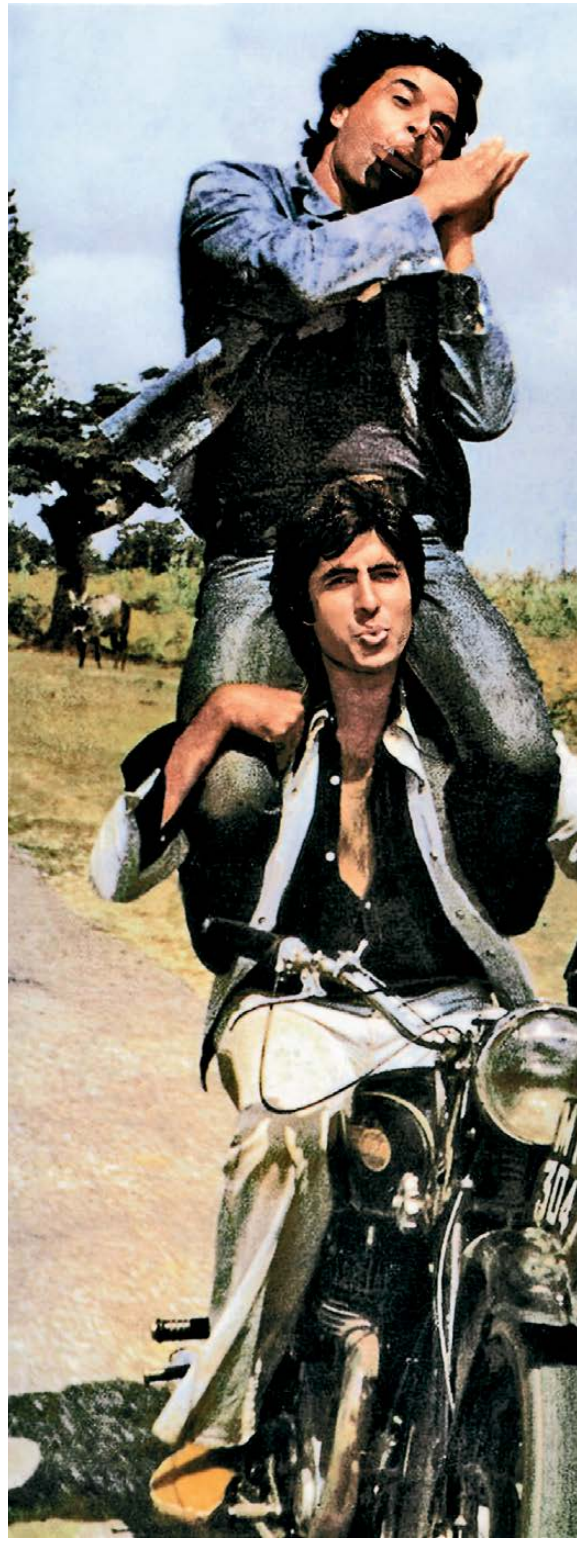
SHOLAY, 1975

THE BIRTH OF THE FANDEMIC

India had seen hits before. But *Sholay* seared into its collective psyche like a badland bullet. The effect was on a scale never seen before—one film creating a new mass folk culture. And a trail of monster blockbusters that still continues

BY SUHANI SINGH



ALAMY

"*Chholey*." Believe it or not, that's what they called it. Notes of scepticism and vinegary derision marked the Hindi cinema universe's first responses to this self-consciously grandiose, Rs 3-crore curry western which, at three hours and 20 minutes, must have seemed like a little too much *chholey*! Trade papers prophesied doom amidst a tepid first fortnight after *Sholay*'s release on August 15, 1975. The commentariat—including, er, INDIA TODAY—reacted negatively to the cultish violence reminiscent of Sergio Leone and Sam Peckinpah. But soon, something started welling up from the street.

At a tactile level, it may have been disorienting at first for audiences—what with India's first stereophonic sound. At some point, though, the compelling drama at the heart of that sheer visual-aural expanse started filtering through. This wasn't just robotic technical wizardry. Mounted



"There has never been a more defining film on the Indian screen. Indian film history can be divided into Sholay BC and Sholay AD"

—SHEKHAR KAPUR
in Sholay: The Making of a Classic